

UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

FRIDAY, 25 SEPTEMBER 2026

18 must-know stories, 12 Prelims facts, 15 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 379 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

[Open this brief online: summaries, Ask Intel and practice MCQs](#)

MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court Reserves Judgment On Sambhal Mosque Committee's Plea Against Survey Order

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Who: Supreme Court

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Report/Index, Judgment

[Live Law: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Foreign Exchange Management (Export and Import of Goods and Services) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026

RESERVE BANK OF INDIA FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT CENTRAL OFFICE Mumbai 400 001 Notification No. FEMA 23(R)/(1)/2026-RB September 22, 2026 Foreign Exchange Management (Export and Import of Goods and Services) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026 In exercise of the powers conferred by Section 7, Section 8, sub-section (6) of Section 10 and sub-section (2) of Section 47 of the Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 (42 of 1999), the Reserve Bank of India makes the following amendments to the Foreign Exchange Management (Export and Import of Goods and Services) Regulations, 2026 [Notification No. FEMA 23(R)/2026-RB dated January 13, 2026] (hereinafter referred to as 'the principal regulations'),...

Where: Mumbai

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

[RBI: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court split on referring EC Act challenge to larger bench; pitches permanent 5-Judge bench for constitutional issues

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Who: Supreme Court

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment, Act/Bill/Rules

[SCC Online: read the source](#) · [also reported by lawstreet.co](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court Closes Punjab's Plea Against Governor Reserving Two Bills For President's Assent

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Where: Punjab · Who: Reserving Two Bills (Governor), Supreme Court

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

[LiveLaw: read the source](#)

Governance & Policy

GS2

MAKE NOTES

IAS officer Mandeep Bhandari appointed chairperson of CBSE

The 2001-batch IAS officer from the AGMUT cadre has held key leadership and administrative roles across Jammu & Kashmir and Central government departments...

Where: Jammu, Kashmir

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy, Education · Prelims angle: Appointment

[The Hindu: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Bihar Cabinet Approves New Proposals Including New Universities

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Where: Bihar · **Who:** Cabinet

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy

[Drishti IAS: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushalya Yojana (DDU-GKY)

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme

[Civildaily: read the source](#) · also reported by [News On AIR](#)

International Relations

GS2

MAKE NOTES

India close to concluding four BITs under updated treaty framework

India is close to concluding bilateral investment treaties with the UK, EU, Oman and Qatar, while the draft of an updated BIT framework awaits Union Cabinet approval...

Where: UK, Oman, Qatar · **Who:** Union Cabinet

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[Business Standard: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Cabinet to take up revamped model bilateral investment treaty to woo global investors

New framework aims to speed up negotiations, preserve India's taxation and judiciary sovereignty, and narrow red lines while expanding protections for outbound investments...

Who: Cabinet

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Governance & Policy, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[BusinessLine: read the source](#) · also reported by [Mint](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Indian Coast Guard Joins QUAD-at-Sea Ship Observer Mission

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme

[ThePrint: read the source](#)

GS1 GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

ICAR-DMAPR's Contribution to Nagori Ashwagandha GI Tag Gains Global Spotlight at G7 Summit

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Syllabus: GS1 / GS2 / GS3: International Relations, History, Art & Culture, Agriculture & Allied

[Indian Council Of Agricultural Research: read the source](#) · also reported by [Greater Kashmir](#)

Health

GS2

MAKE NOTES

FSSAI proposes nationwide ban on manufacture and sale of analogue paneer

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Who: FSSAI

Syllabus: GS2: Health

[Civildaily: read the source](#)

Economy

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

Travel & Tourism Development Index (TTDI) 2026

The World Economic Forum released the Travel & Tourism Development Index (TTDI) 2026, with India improving to 31st position from 39th in 2024. About Travel & Tourism Development Index 2026 Travel & Tourism Development Index assesses the conditions that support sustainable and resilient tourism development.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Economy, International Relations · Prelims angle: Report/Index

[ForumIAS: read the source](#) · also reported by [The Economic Times](#)

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

Govt disburses Rs. 36,754 crore under PLI schemes till June 30

These schemes have led to the employment generation of over 14.57 lakh (direct and indirect) along with Rs. 36,754 crore of cumulative incentives disbursed so far: DPIIT Electronics manufacturing gets Rs. 19,091 crore; schemes draw Rs. 2.58 lakh crore investment, Rs. 15.53 lakh crore exports and 14.57 lakh jobs... Electronics manufacturing gets Rs. 19,091 crore; schemes draw Rs. 2.58 lakh crore investment, Rs. 15.53 lakh crore exports and 14.57 lakh jobs

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme, Data/Stats

[BusinessLine: read the source](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

India's forex reserves fall \$14.89 billion to \$766 billion: RBI data

India's forex reserves dropped by USD 14.881 billion to USD 765.901 billion during the week ended September 18 due to a fall in foreign currency assets, according to the RBI data released on Friday. In the previous reporting week, forex reserves had fallen by USD 4.924 billion to USD 780.782 billion. Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in foreign exchange reserves. The RBI's Weekly Statistical Supplement stated that the decline was mainly driven by a fall in foreign currency assets, the largest component of India's foreign exchange reserves, news agency ANI reported.

Where: US · Who: RBI

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

[Business Standard: read the source](#) · also reported by [Economic Times](#)

Infrastructure & Energy

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

India-Australia trade pact: CECA, BIT talks to deepen ties in critical minerals, investment

India and Australia are negotiating a broader CECA and bilateral investment treaty, with critical minerals, investment, education and talent emerging as key areas.

Where: Australia

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Infrastructure & Energy, International Relations · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[Mint: read the source](#)

Science & Technology

GS3

MAKE NOTES

DRDO signs first deep-tech pact with Zero mK India for indigenous dilution refrigerator

DRDO has signed an agreement with Zero mK India for the development of a dilution refrigerator. This project will support quantum applications and enhance India's technological capabilities. Monitoring will be conducted by the director of DRDO's Solid State Physics Laboratory and his team. This collaboration aims to reduce dependence on foreign cryogenic infrastructure for quantum technologies. The agreement is part of a larger Rs 500-crore initiative for deep-tech innovations.

Who: DRDO · Prelims: The agreement is part of a larger Rs 500-crore initiative for deep-tech innovations.

Syllabus: GS3: Science & Technology, Defence · **Prelims angle:** Agreement/MoU

[Economic Times: read the source](#)

Internal Security

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Centre extends AFSPA in parts of Manipur, Nagaland and Arunachal Pradesh for six months

The Centre has announced an extension of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act in several northeastern states. The law has been extended for six months in specified regions of Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh, and Manipur. Nine districts of Nagaland and certain districts of Arunachal Pradesh are also included under AFSPA. In Manipur, the disturbed area declaration covers the entire state except certain police station jurisdictions.

Where: Manipur, Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh · **Prelims:** In Manipur, the disturbed area declaration covers the entire state except certain police station jurisdictions.

Syllabus: GS3: Internal Security · **Prelims angle:** Act/Bill/Rules

[Economic Times: read the source](#) · [also reported by TheWire.in](#)

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

India reserves rights to join Russia's CBAM dispute with EU as third party at WTO

India and 17 other countries, including the US, UK and China, have reserved third-party rights in Russia's WTO dispute against the European Union's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism. The WTO Dispute Settlement Body has agreed to establish a panel to examine Russia's claims that CBAM creates trade barriers and violates WTO rules.

[Economic Times: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

Nepal PM proposes establishing Himalayan Climate Resilience Mechanism with India, China

Balen Shah, in his maiden address to the 81st session of the UN General Assembly, told world leaders that a warming climate is destabilising the fragile Himalayan ecology...

[The Hindu: source](#)

GOVERNANCE & POLICY

QUICK READ

Cabinet Approves Major Rail and Highway Projects Worth Over Rs. 48,000 Crore to Boost Connectivity

[News On AIR: source](#)

GOVERNANCE & POLICY

SCHEME

QUICK READ

Govt launches Rs 200 crore MAHA Water Mission to support startups

[DD News: source](#)

POLITY & CONSTITUTION

ACT/BILL/RULES

QUICK READ

Rajya Sabha passes Central Armed Police Forces Bill, 2026 with voice vote

[News On AIR: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

QUICK READ

New Begonia species discovered in Arunachal's Keyi Panyor district

[India Today NE: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

PLACE IN NEWS

QUICK READ

Three rescued bear cubs begin journey back to wild in Arunachal's Pakke Tiger Reserve

[India Today NE: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

PLACE IN NEWS

QUICK READ

6th Cycle of Tiger Reserve Evaluation Launched

[PIB: source](#)

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY

QUICK READ

ONGC Discovers Natural Gas in Mahanadi Basin

[Drishhti IAS: source](#)

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

QUICK READ

INDIA-US JOINT MILITARY EXERCISE YUDH ABHYAS 2026 COMMENCES AT AULI AND MAHAJAN[PIB: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

EAM's remarks during the inaugural meeting of "Group of Friends on Safety & Security of Shipping & Seafarers" (GoF on S4)[Ministry of External Affairs: source](#)

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

QUICK READ

India, US soldiers conduct counterterrorism joint exercise[Myanmar International TV: source](#)**EDITORIAL WATCH***What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.***GS1 GS2 GS3 UPSC Editorial Analysis: Analyzing India's Public Expenditure on Education: The 6% GDP Promise vs Reality**

According to data from the Union Budgets, Economic Surveys, and UNESCO reports, combined public expenditure (Centre and States) on education... Topic: Issues relating to development and management of Social Sector/Services relating to Health, Education, Human Resources. Introduction The target of allocating 6% of Gross Domestic Product (GDP) to education has been India's longest-standing policy goal in social infrastructure.

[Insights on India](#)**GS2 A chance to retreat: On Donald Trump, the Greenland agreement**

The Greenland agreement allows U.S. President Donald Trump to scale down his threats

[The Hindu](#)**GS1 GS2 GS3 Smart rice policy would be nice**

In the 2026-27 cycle, India's rice production is projected to fall by 6.5% compared to the previous year, largely due to monsoon rainfall being 15% below the seasonal average. This shortfall poses significant challenges for farmers, likely leading to financial hardship as both yields and cultivated areas decline. However, with high existing stockpiles, domestic markets may not face critical shortages.

[Economic Times](#)**GS1 A nation's song: On Vande Mataram's rendition**

Vande Mataram's rendition must be in the spirit of "unity in diversity"

[The Hindu](#)**GS2 ECI must answer : SIR mess is a blot on Indian democracy**

Open the piece for its argument.

[The Tribune](#)**GS2 Why the Trump-Xi summit just produced a truce, not a breakthrough**

The Donald Trump-Xi Jinping Summit is best understood as the TRUCE, shaping a bipolar international system amid its multipolar pushbacks.

[ThePrint](#)**GS2 Show what you do & how: A reshuffle won't fix Election Commission, only trustworthiness that it can demonstrate will**

The Election Commission of India is facing a crisis of public confidence due to recent events. Rebuilding trust will require demonstrating its trustworthiness rather than relying on the reputation of its commissioners. Implementing reforms such as improved transparency and external scrutiny could help restore public faith. Major decisions should be accompanied by a clear rationale and dissent should be documented for public understanding.

[Economic Times](#)**GS2 GS3 Amazon doesn't want Meta's AI agent to shop on its site—where does that leave users of personal bots?**

Meta's Muse has gained popularity as a personal AI agent—enough for Amazon to bar it in its own business interest. Expect a corporate fight over which agents get access to what—and with luck, a treaty of mutual operability that won't force us to hire multiple agents.

[Mint](#)**GS2 Poshan Maah 2026: Break the intergenerational cycle of malnutrition**

This article is authored by Lalita Panicker.

[Hindustan Times](#)**GS2 Narrow off-ramp for US at UNGA**

Iran has signalled that it is ready for diplomacy, but won't bow to pressure from Washington. The US must use this to end the ill-conceived war

[Hindustan Times](#)

GS3 UPI's real value isn't MDR revenue. It is the economy it makes visible

UPI has created a digital trail of India's spending and small-business activity. A new MDR model should not undermine the ecosystem that made that possible.

[ThePrint](#)

GS2 FSSAI finally steps up on warning labels

Given India's burden of lifestyle diseases has been increasing sharply over decades, regulatory interventions such as FoPL have been imperative for long...

[Hindustan Times](#)

GS3 Mint Quick Edit | IRDAI's reform proposals could fix what's broken and thus help insure more of India

The insurance regulator's proposals could rein back runaway misselling and turn the sector more customer-friendly. A country that's sparsely insured should focus on long-term market expansion.

[Mint](#)

GS2 India's UNGA story | From Rao-Vajpayee consensus to Modi-Jaishankar pattern

Open the piece for its argument.

[Deccan Herald](#)

GS2 GS3 Invisible work: Why unpaid labour done by women mustn't go unaccounted for

We must include it in our calculation of gross domestic product (GDP). Estimates vary, but there is little doubt that gender inequity in the distribution of care work explains the economic and social disempowerment of women.

[Mint](#)

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

What is Bengal's controversial anti-Goonda Bill?

[Indian Express](#)

What is analogue paneer, and why is FSSAI cracking down on it?

[The Hindu](#)

An expert explains | As Xi-Trump meet, why an island 15,000 km away matters

[Indian Express](#)

Explained: How Trump's diplomatic week exposed the limits of his power

[Deccan Herald](#)

Explained | What is 'Taiwan independence' and what does that mean for Trump and Xi?

[Deccan Herald](#)

How Iran's 7-day plan to end war with US mirrors June memorandum

[Indian Express](#)

Decoding the dissent inside ECI Objections from two commissioners have renewed the debate on the ECI's independence. An impeachment notice is pending and another is planned.

[Frontline](#)

Should permanent membership, veto powers of the UNSC be abolished?

[Civildaily](#)

Why is New York City pausing some AI tools in schools? The Mayor of New York Zohran Mamdani and Schools Chancellor Kamar H. Samuels on September 2 imposed a one-year moratorium on student-facing generative AI for pupils up to eighth grade for the 2026–27 academic year...

[The Hindu](#)

Trump pulls out all the stops for Xi Jinping's US visit: But is Beijing impressed?

[Firstpost](#)

Netanyahu faces another UN walkout: The history of such protests at the world body

[Indian Express](#)

What does the Centre's new mining law say and why are states opposing it?

[Indian Express](#)

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- How a Campaign Against Muslim Voter Deletions – Aided by a Report on The Wire – Forced the Election Commission to Act (Polity & Constitution) [TheWire.in](#)
- Probe Finds Alleged Corruption in Jal Jeevan Mission Work Done in Madhya Pradesh, Contractor, Govt Officials Booked (Infrastructure & Energy) [The Wire](#)
- Cumulative FDI during 2014-26 reaches \$843 billion, says Piyush Goyal (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- India's growth outlook strengthens as economists see resilient incomes, stable policy: WEF (Economy) [Mint](#)
- WMA Limit for Government of India for October 2026 – March 2027 (Economy) [RBI](#)
- US, India should intensify efforts to conclude "historic" trade deal, lower tariffs: USIBC President Atul Keshap (International Relations) [Economic Times](#)
- Delhi Court Seeks Fresh Action Taken Report On Plea Alleging Electoral Roll Irregularities By ECI... (Polity & Constitution) [LiveLaw](#)
- 12 years of 'Make in India' in 12 metrics — Low and patchy impact on growth, employment & global share (Economy) [The Hindu](#)
- India doesn't plan huge changes to dispute resolution with foreign companies, source says (International Relations) [Economic Times](#)
- Western Ghats ESA: Keralam submits recommendations to Centre, seeks limiting area to 8,590 sq km (Environment & Ecology) [The Hindu](#)
- IIM Bangalore and the Ministry of Minority Affairs sign MoUs to strengthen public programme delivery and innovation initiatives (Social Justice & Welfare) [businessnewsthisweek.com](#)
- India-UK trade deal: CBIC eases paperwork for UK imports seeking preferential tariffs (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- Mexico, Brazil, UK see rising medical device imports, opening export opportunities for India: Report (International Relations) [Economic Times](#)
- LIC, New India Assurance veterans appointed as IRDAI members (Economy) [The Indian Express](#)
- India's private capex estimated at Rs. 3.2 lakh crore in 2026-27: RBI (Economy) [BusinessLine](#)
- US President backs IMEC, stresses on shifting energy infrastructure away from Iranian checkpoints (International Relations) [News On AIR](#)
- Government Clarifies UPI MDR Will Not Burden Small Merchants or Make Digital Payments Expensive (Economy) [News On AIR](#)
- India committed to eliminating Hepatitis B, C as public health threats by 2030, says Health Secretary (Health) [News On AIR](#)
- Indian agriculture enters new phase as diets, incomes and climate reshape farming: Report (Agriculture & Allied) [Economic Times](#)
- India-US trade deal 90 per cent complete, final details being worked out: US official (International Relations) [BusinessLine](#)
- Xbox controllers can operate these weapons: US deploys high-energy systems in Strait of Hormuz to counter drones & missiles (Defence) [Economic Times](#)
- NISAR Satellite Tracks Lava From Volcano Waking After 500 Years (Science & Technology) [tovima.com](#)
- India's space sector gets cybersecurity boost as CERT-In, SIA-India release joint guidelines (Internal Security) [DD News](#)
- Ethanol can help raise farmers' income and reduce fuel imports: Gadkari (Infrastructure & Energy) [BusinessLine](#)
- EAM Jaishankar calls for inclusive global trade laws as India hosts UNCITRAL's 60th anniversary conference (International Relations) [DD News](#)
- MoD Signs Contract for SAT-SAAW Glide Bombs for IAF (Defence) [Drishti IAS](#)
- IIM Jammu, Ladakh administration join hands for satellite campus in Leh (Education) [Careers360](#)
- Make in India initiative completes 12 years (Economy) [News On AIR](#)
- RBI Bulletin (Economy) [RBI](#)
- Plea In Supreme Court Seeks Prosecution Of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, SIT Inquiry Into SIR Voter Deletions (Polity & Constitution) [Live Law](#)
- SC asks BCI if it will withdraw upper age limit for law admissions (Polity & Constitution) [Deccan Herald](#)
- Indian Railways approves Rs 4,178 crore projects in Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh to boost train operations (Infrastructure & Energy) [The Indian Express](#)
- Propriety Questions Emerge As Son Of Justice SC Sharma, Who Heard ECI & Medha Roopam Cases, Is Election... (Polity & Constitution) [Live Law](#)
- Delhi Riots UAPA Case : Supreme Court Relaxes Meeran Haider's Bail Condition On Attendance, Refuses To... (Polity & Constitution) [Live Law](#)
- Beyond Buyer-Seller Ties: Canada-based Geopolitical Monitor signals India-Russia defence partnership entering a new era (International Relations) [organiser.org](#)
- Supreme Court Dismisses Plea Seeking Hindi As Official Language Of Apex Court (Polity & Constitution) [Live Law](#)
- India presses for zero-tolerance on terrorism, predictable climate finance at UN meetings (Internal Security) [Daily Excelsior](#)
- Supreme Court Refers Plea To Increase State Bar Councils' Strength To Attorney General (Polity & Constitution) [Live Law](#)
- Türkiye aims to turn climate pledges into action at COP31: environment minister (Environment & Ecology) [TRT World](#)
- Myanmar Drone Training Case: Delhi Court Allows 6 Ukrainians, One US National To Travel Abroad (Internal Security) [TheWire.in](#)
- Monsoon Predictability in India (Geography) [NEXT IAS](#)

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 18 must-know, 12 Prelims facts, 41 in the news, 15 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — International Relations (7), Polity & Constitution (5), Governance & Policy (5), Economy (3), Environment & Ecology (3), Infrastructure & Energy (2), Defence (2), Internal Security (1), Science & Technology (1), Health (1). **Nothing today in** — Social Justice & Welfare, Education, Agriculture & Allied, Disaster Management, History, Art & Culture, Geography, Society, Ethics &

Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 1 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 2 · Political change in the neighbourhood: 1 · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 1 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 2

Full text — 0 of 57 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 6, Economic Times 5, Indian Express 5, Mint 4, ThePrint 3, Civildaily 3, Hindustan Times 3, Deccan Herald 3, Business Standard 2, BusinessLine 2, Drishti IAS 2, News On AIR 2, India Today NE 2, PIB 2

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